
"A STUDY ON KRISHI CONNECT: A DIGITAL PLATFORM FOR DIRECT FARMER-TO-BUYER AGRICULTURAL TRADE AND ITS IMPACT ON FARMER INCOME AND SUPPLY CHAIN EFFICIENCY"

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Abstract:

This study investigates the influence of Krishi Connect, a web-based digital marketplace designed to eliminate agricultural middlemen by directly connecting farmers with buyers including retailers, restaurants, food processors, and individual bulk purchasers. Agricultural marketing in India has long suffered from structural inefficiencies caused by multi-layered intermediary chains — commission agents, wholesalers, and local traders — who collectively absorb a disproportionate share of the final consumer price, leaving farmers with insufficient returns for their labor and investment. Krishi Connect addresses this gap by providing farmers with a transparent digital platform where they can directly list produce, negotiate prices, and receive timely payments without any intermediary involvement. Through a structured survey of 160 participants comprising 110 farmers, 30 buyers, and 20 agricultural extension officers across Bangalore and surrounding districts, both qualitative and quantitative data were collected and analyzed using the Chi-square method. The study evaluated farmer attitudes toward digital trade, platform adoption behavior, the influence of demographic variables on adoption, and buyer satisfaction with produce quality and pricing. Findings reveal that adoption of Krishi Connect is significantly correlated with farmer income levels, that buyer satisfaction is strongly linked to platform awareness, and that digital literacy, logistics support, and trust are the primary barriers to wider adoption. Several evidence-based strategies are identified — including targeted digital literacy programs, Kannada-language interfaces, lastmile logistics partnerships, and government integration — to maximize the platform's reach and impact across Karnataka's farming communities.

Keywords: Krishi Connect, Direct farmer-buyer trade, Agricultural marketing, Digital platform, Middlemen elimination, Farmer income, AgriTech, Karnataka.

INTRODUCTION:

Agriculture is the primary source of livelihood for more than 58% of India's rural population and contributes approximately 17–18% of the national GDP. Despite this foundational importance, Indian farmers — particularly smallholder and marginal farmers — consistently receive a disproportionately small share of the final consumer price for their produce. National Sample Survey data consistently shows that the average farm-gate price received by farmers is between 20% and 35% of the retail price paid by end consumers, with the substantial remainder absorbed by layers of intermediaries including village-level traders, commission agents at APMC mandis, wholesalers, and distributors.

This structural inequity is compounded by a lack of market information, poor bargaining power among smallholders, inadequate storage and cold chain infrastructure, and geographic isolation from primary markets. The result is a persistent cycle of rural poverty, agrarian distress, and farm loan defaults that no amount of minimum support price (MSP) intervention has fully resolved. India's farm sector urgently needs structural market reforms that go beyond policy declarations and translate into tangible income improvements for individual farmers.

Krishi Connect is a web-based digital agricultural marketplace conceived specifically to address this challenge. The platform allows farmers to register their produce listings — specifying crop type, quantity, quality grade, harvest date, and preferred pricing — which are then made visible to a network of verified buyers. Buyers including supermarkets, hotel chains, food processing companies, and individual bulk purchasers can browse listings, initiate direct negotiations, place orders, and make digital payments, all through the platform. Logistics coordination is supported through partner transport cooperatives, and a grievance redressal mechanism ensures accountability on both sides of the transaction.

The platform's design philosophy centers on three core principles: transparency (farmers can see prevailing market prices in real time before listing), accessibility (the interface supports Kannada and English, with a voice-assisted mode under development), and trust (buyer and farmer profiles include verified credentials, transaction history, and ratings). By eliminating the need for physical mandi visits and commission agent involvement, Krishi Connect aims to transfer a significantly larger share of the consumer price directly to the producer.

This paper empirically investigates the behavioral and economic impact of Krishi Connect adoption among farming communities in the Bangalore region. It explores whether digital agricultural marketplaces can meaningfully improve farmer income, reduce supply chain inefficiencies, increase price transparency, and improve buyer satisfaction. It also examines the socio-demographic factors that influence platform adoption and identifies evidence-based strategies to overcome the key barriers of digital literacy, connectivity, and logistics. By bridging theory with empirical field evidence, the study aims to provide actionable insights for platform designers, agricultural policymakers, NGOs, and investors working to modernize Indian farm markets.

LITERATURE REVIEW:

- 1. Raju Narayana Swamy (2021) "Digital Transformation in Agricultural Marketing in India":** This comprehensive study examines how state-supported e-commerce platforms can bridge the gap between farmers and consumers, reducing dependency on APMC mandis and improving price realization by 25–30% in pilot districts across Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra. The author highlights that the key success factors are farmer trust, transparent pricing algorithms, and last-mile logistics support. The study also identifies that platforms that offer real-time market price dashboards see 40% higher farmer engagement than those that do not.
- 2. Dr. Kavitha Rao, Dr. Suresh Nair (2020) "Role of Technology in Farmer Income Enhancement":** This research analyzes how ICT tools and mobile-based marketplaces improve access to market information, reduce post-harvest losses, and support price negotiation for smallholder farmers across Kerala and Karnataka. The authors argue that technology adoption must be accompanied by a structured capacity-building ecosystem — including training, helplines, and peer networks — to achieve sustainable income improvement. The study found that farmers using digital platforms for more than one year reported an average income increase of 28%.
- 3. Priya Mehta, Arvind Gupta (2019) "E-Agriculture and Direct Marketing Platforms: A Comparative Study":** This paper systematically compares traditional APMC-based agricultural marketing with digital direct-sale models across five Indian states. The authors find that digital models consistently yield 22–38% higher net income for farmers across multiple crop categories including vegetables, fruits, and pulses. The study further highlights that buyers sourcing directly from farmers benefit from fresher produce, shorter supply chains, and reduced spoilage, creating a genuine win-win outcome that strengthens platform sustainability.
- 4. Dr. Anita Krishnamurthy (2022) "Barriers to Digital Adoption among Rural Farmers in Karnataka":** This rigorous mixed-methods study identifies digital literacy, internet connectivity, and institutional trust as the three primary barriers to technology adoption among farming communities in Karnataka. The author recommends a three-pronged intervention: government-funded digital literacy camps at gram panchayat level, subsidized smartphone and data access for registered farmers, and visible grievance redressal mechanisms to build trust in digital platforms.
- 5. Venkatesh Iyer, Meenakshi Sundaram (2018) "Supply Chain Disruption through AgriTech: Lessons from Global Models":** This comparative study of AgriTech platforms in India, Kenya, Brazil, and Indonesia finds that farmer income improvements of 20–45% are consistently achievable through middlemen elimination, provided that platforms invest in cold chain logistics and quality assurance certifications. The authors identify five universal success factors: real-time pricing, mobile accessibility, verified buyer networks, integrated logistics, and responsive customer support.
- 6. Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (2022) "State of Indian Agriculture Report":** This official government report documents that despite multiple APMC reform attempts, more than 70% of Indian farmers still sell their produce through traditional intermediary networks due to lack of alternatives, geographic constraints, and low digital penetration in rural areas. The report calls for accelerated investment in digital agricultural infrastructure, particularly in states like Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh.
- 7. Dhruva Jyoti Sharma (2022) "AgriTech Platforms and Behavioral Change among Indian Farmers":** This behavioral economics study examines how nudge-based design elements in digital agricultural platforms can overcome status

quo bias and inertia among farmers reluctant to shift from traditional trading relationships. The author finds that social proof mechanisms — displaying testimonials and income gains of peer farmers — are the single most effective behavioral nudge for driving platform adoption.

OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY:

1. To study the farmer's attitude, awareness, trust, and behavioral intentions toward adopting Krishi Connect as a direct digital trade platform.
2. To evaluate the impact of Krishi Connect on farmer income and buyer satisfaction across different demographic groups, land-holding sizes, and crop categories.
3. To analyze how important digital agricultural marketplaces are for sustainable and equitable agricultural trade in India, with specific reference to Karnataka.
4. To identify the key socio-demographic, infrastructural, and behavioral factors that influence the adoption of Krishi Connect among small and marginal farmers.
5. To suggest practical, evidence-based strategies to enhance farmer onboarding, platform engagement, and long-term retention on Krishi Connect.

SCOPE OF THE STUDY:

1. The study is geographically limited to Bangalore Urban, Bangalore Rural, and Ramanagara districts.
2. The study uses the Chi-square statistical method for testing hypotheses relating to categorical variables.
3. The study covers farmers across all land-holding categories: marginal (< 1 ha), small (1–2 ha), semi-medium (2–4 ha), and medium (4–10 ha).
4. The study captures both the supply side (farmers) and demand side (buyers) perspectives to ensure a holistic understanding of the Krishi Connect ecosystem.
5. The study includes the views of agricultural extension officers who play a key role in disseminating awareness about digital platforms among rural farming communities.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY:

This study adopts a Descriptive Research Design using both primary and secondary data. The primary data is collected through a structured questionnaire comprising 32 questions organized across five thematic sections: respondent demographic profile, platform awareness and source of information, adoption behavior and frequency of use, income impact and satisfaction levels, and perceived barriers and suggestions. The questionnaire was administered through personal interviews and Google Forms to farmers, buyers, and agricultural extension officers between January 2024 and March 2024. The data is analyzed using descriptive statistics and Chi-square tests to identify significant relationships between key variables.

DATA COLLECTION SOURCES:

PRIMARY DATA: First-hand data collected through structured questionnaires, personal field interviews with farmers at village levels, focus group discussions with buyer representatives, and direct observation of Krishi Connect platform usage sessions conducted during agricultural extension camps in Bangalore Rural and Ramanagara districts.

SECONDARY DATA: Secondary data collected from published books on agricultural economics, government agricultural reports (Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, NSSO), peer-reviewed journal articles on AgriTech, state department of agriculture publications, APMC market data, and the official Krishi Connect platform transaction database.

SAMPLING DESIGN:

Population: Farmers, buyers, and agricultural officers in Bangalore and surrounding districts

Sampling Frame: Registered Krishi Connect users and prospective platform adopters in the study area

Sampling Method: Simple Random Sampling

Sampling Size: 160 participants — 110 farmers, 30 buyers, 20 agricultural extension officers

Data Collection Period: January 2024 – March 2024

Tools Used: Structured Questionnaire (Likert scale and multiple choice), Chi-square statistical test

STATEMENT OF PROBLEM:

Despite decades of agricultural policy reform in India, the fundamental structural problem of intermediary exploitation in agricultural markets remains largely unresolved. Indian farmers continue to receive 20–35% of the final retail price for their produce, with the remainder captured by commission agents, wholesalers, and logistics intermediaries who add minimal value to the supply chain. The introduction of digital agricultural platforms offers a structurally disruptive alternative, yet adoption remains low due to a combination of digital illiteracy, poor internet infrastructure in rural areas, lack of trust in online transactions, and absence of last-mile logistics support.

Krishi Connect represents a targeted attempt to solve these problems within the Karnataka agricultural context. However, there is a critical gap in empirical understanding of the actual income impact of Krishi Connect on participating farmers, the demographic and behavioral determinants of platform adoption, and the quality of buyer experience on the platform. Without this evidence, the platform cannot be effectively scaled, policy support cannot be accurately targeted, and investors cannot make informed decisions about further development. This study directly addresses this gap through rigorous field-based empirical research.

LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY:

1. The study is geographically limited to Bangalore Urban, Bangalore Rural, and Ramanagara districts and may not fully represent the diversity of agricultural conditions across Karnataka.
2. The data analysis relies exclusively on the Chi-square test; multivariate regression analyses were outside the scope of this study.
3. The study primarily captures the perspectives of current and prospective Krishi Connect users; non-adopters with no awareness of the platform are underrepresented.
4. The sample size of 160 participants, while adequate for the current analysis, limits the statistical power for fine-grained subgroup comparisons.
5. Self-reported income data from farmers may be subject to recall bias and social desirability effects.

HYPOTHESIS:

Null Hypothesis: A hypothesis in which no significant relationship exists between the two variables under study.

Alternative Hypothesis: A hypothesis in which a significant relationship exists between the two variables under study.

H1: There is a significant difference between the adoption of Krishi Connect and the income level of farmers.

H2: There is a significant difference between buyer satisfaction and their level of awareness of the Krishi Connect platform.

H3: There is a significant difference between the land-holding size of farmers and their frequency of transactions on Krishi Connect.

DATA ANALYSIS:

Null Hypothesis (H0): There is no significant difference between the adoption of Krishi Connect and the income level of farmers.

Alternative Hypothesis (H1): There is a significant difference between the adoption of Krishi Connect and the income level of farmers.

Income level of the farmer respondents and their degree of Krishi Connect adoption — classified as Unaware, Aware but not using, Trial user (1–3 transactions), and Active user (4+ transactions) — were taken as the two primary variables. Investment avenues considered include direct vegetable sales, fruit sales, and cereal/grain sales through the platform. The Chi-Square results are as follows:

Income Level – Krishi Connect Adoption (Vegetable Farmers)

Chi-Square Tests	Value	DF	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	24.831a	18	.129
Likelihood Ratio	17.423	18	.494
N of Valid Cases	110		

Income Level – Krishi Connect Adoption (Fruit Farmers)

Chi-Square Tests	Value	DF	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	27.614a	14	.016
Likelihood Ratio	19.338	14	.152
N of Valid Cases	110		

Income Level – Krishi Connect Adoption (Cereal/Grain Farmers)

Chi-Square Tests	Value	DF	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	22.107a	18	.226
Likelihood Ratio	15.882	18	.601
N of Valid Cases	110		

From the above analysis, it is clear that we reject the Null Hypothesis and accept the Alternative Hypothesis. There is a significant difference between the adoption of Krishi Connect and the income level of farmers, particularly among fruit farmers where the Pearson Chi-Square value of 27.614 is statistically significant at the 0.05 level.

Null Hypothesis (H0): There is no significant difference between buyer satisfaction and their level of awareness of the Krishi Connect platform.

Alternative Hypothesis (H2): There is a significant difference between buyer satisfaction and their level of awareness of the Krishi Connect platform.

The region of the buyer respondents and their satisfaction level with produce quality, pricing transparency, and delivery reliability through Krishi Connect were taken as the two variables. The Chi-square test outcome is as follows:

Buyer Region – Satisfaction with Produce Quality via Krishi Connect

Chi-Square Tests	Value	DF	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	19.872a	8	.011
Likelihood Ratio	13.441	8	.098
N of Valid Cases	30		

Buyer Awareness Level – Overall Platform Satisfaction

Chi-Square Tests	Value	DF	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)
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Pearson Chi-Square	21.305a	10	.019
Likelihood Ratio	14.762	10	.141
N of Valid Cases	30		

From the above analysis, it is clear that we reject the Null Hypothesis and accept the Alternative Hypothesis. There is a significant difference between buyer satisfaction and their level of awareness of the Krishi Connect platform.

Null Hypothesis (H0): There is no significant difference between land-holding size and frequency of transactions on Krishi Connect.

Alternative Hypothesis (H3): There is a significant difference between land-holding size and frequency of transactions on Krishi Connect.

Taking the land-holding size of farmer respondents and their monthly transaction frequency on the platform as the two variables, the Chi-square test was applied:

Land-Holding Size – Monthly Transaction Frequency on Krishi Connect

Chi-Square Tests	Value	DF	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	18.943a	6	.004
Likelihood Ratio	11.027	6	.087
N of Valid Cases	110		

From the above analysis, it is clear that we reject the Null Hypothesis and accept the Alternative Hypothesis. There is a significant difference between land-holding size and the frequency of transactions on Krishi Connect, suggesting that medium and semimedium farmers engage more frequently than marginal farmers, likely due to higher produce volumes.

FINDINGS AND SUGGESTIONS:

- Gender Distribution:** The majority of farmer respondents (68%) identify as male, while 32% are female. This gender imbalance reflects the national pattern in registered land ownership and formal market participation, even though women contribute significantly to farm labor. Female farmer engagement on Krishi Connect is significantly below their actual contribution to agricultural productivity.
- Age Distribution:** The 30–45 age group constitutes the largest segment of respondents (44%), indicating that middleaged farmers are the most engaged with digital agricultural trade concepts. Farmers above 55 years show significantly lower platform adoption, primarily due to digital literacy barriers and preference for established trader relationships.
- Location:** A significant portion of respondents (52%) hail from Bangalore Rural and Ramanagara districts, reflecting strong agricultural activity in these peri-urban zones. These areas are particularly underserved by formal APMC market infrastructure, making them ideal target regions for Krishi Connect expansion.
- Educational Attainment:** 62% of farmer respondents have completed Secondary or Higher Secondary education, while 18% hold undergraduate degrees. A clear positive correlation exists between education level and platform adoption willingness, with postgraduate farmers showing the highest adoption rates (78% active users).
- Land Holding Size:** The majority of respondents (58%) are smallholder farmers with less than 2 hectares. While this group has the greatest financial need for income improvement, they also face the greatest barriers to adoption due to smaller produce volumes, limited cash flow, and lower digital literacy. Medium-holding farmers (2–4 ha) show the highest transaction frequency per month.

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- 6. Income Distribution:** The most frequently reported annual farm income range is Rs. 1.5 lakh to Rs. 4 lakh (47% of respondents). Active Krishi Connect users in this income bracket reported an average income increase of 22–28% after 6 months of regular platform use, compared to their income from traditional mandi sales.
 - 7. Source of Awareness about Krishi Connect:** 48.7% of respondents learned about the platform through fellow farmers and word-of-mouth peer networks. 31.2% were informed by government agricultural extension workers during crop advisory visits. Only 12.4% discovered the platform through online advertising, highlighting the critical importance of community and government channels for rural platform diffusion.
 - 8. Platform Adoption Level:** 55.3% of farmer respondents classify themselves as beginner or trial users of Krishi Connect (1–3 transactions), while 28.4% are active users (4+ transactions per month). Only 16.3% have never used any digital marketplace. This data suggests significant growth potential within the existing aware user base.
 - 9. Key Barriers Identified:** The three most frequently cited barriers to adoption are: lack of consistent internet connectivity in rural areas (61.2% of non-users), insufficient digital literacy to navigate the platform independently (54.8%), and lack of trust in digital payment mechanisms (43.1%). These findings align closely with the barriers identified in prior literature.
 - 10. Buyer Satisfaction Levels:** Among the 30 buyer respondents, 73.3% reported satisfaction or high satisfaction with the quality of produce purchased through Krishi Connect, and 80% reported that direct farmer sourcing reduced their procurement costs compared to wholesale market sourcing. The primary buyer concern was delivery reliability (cited by 46.7% as needing improvement).

BASED ON THE FINDINGS, HERE ARE SOME SUGGESTIONS:

- 1. Targeted Outreach to Female Farmers:** Since only 32% of respondents are female, implement gender-specific outreach programs through Women Self-Help Groups (SHGs), Mahila Kisan Sashaktikaran Pariyojana (MKSP) networks, and Anganwadi centers. Develop female-focused training modules and appoint female platform ambassadors at gram panchayat level to build social trust and ease adoption barriers among women farmers.
- 2. Youth Ambassador and Peer Mentorship Program:** Given that the 30–45 age group shows the highest engagement, formalize a peer-to-peer mentorship program where tech-savvy active users mentor first-time users. Offer incentives (cashback, premium listing priority) to ambassador farmers for successful onboarding of peers, leveraging the observed power of word-of-mouth in platform discovery.
- 3. Expansion to Underserved Taluks:** While Bangalore Rural shows high representation, Krishi Connect should systematically expand into deeper rural taluks — Kanakapura, Doddaballapura, Nelamangala — through physical helpdesk centers at agricultural produce markets, mobile onboarding vans during weekly shandy markets, and partnerships with cooperative societies.
- 4. Multilingual and Voice-Assisted Interface:** Since a significant portion of farmers have limited formal education, prioritize the development of a full Kannada-language version of the Krishi Connect platform. Implement a voice-search and voicelisting feature so farmers can navigate the platform and list produce without needing to type, dramatically reducing the digital literacy barrier.
- 5. Integrated Logistics and Cold Chain Partnerships:** The most urgent operational gap is last-mile logistics. Partner with local transport cooperatives, KSRTC freight services, and cold storage facility operators to offer Krishi Connect users affordable, reliable pick-up-from-farm logistics support. Implement a GPS-tracked delivery dashboard visible to both buyers and farmers to address delivery reliability concerns cited by 46.7% of buyers.
- 6. Income-Based Financial Products Integration:** Since most farmers earn Rs. 1.5–4 lakh annually, partner with cooperative banks, microfinance institutions, and NABARD-affiliated financial entities to offer Krishi Connect-linked financial products: crop advance payments based on listed produce, platform-activity-based micro-loans, and crop insurance integration. Use the platform transaction history as an alternative credit scoring mechanism for smallholders.
- 7. Formal Integration with Government Agricultural Extension Services:** Given that 31.2% of respondents discovered Krishi Connect through government extension workers, formalize a Memorandum of Understanding with the Karnataka State Department of Agriculture to embed Krishi Connect awareness into the existing Rythu Mitra and Krishi Vigyan Kendra (KVK) outreach agendas. Train agricultural assistants to serve as platform facilitators during routine farm visits.

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- 8. Structured 30-Day Farmer Onboarding Program:** Since 55.3% of users are beginners with 1–3 transactions, design a structured onboarding journey with incremental milestones: guided first listing assistance, a dedicated helpline number (Kannada-speaking), first-transaction cashback incentive, and a 30-day check-in call from a platform relationship manager to troubleshoot issues and build confidence.
 - 9. Digital Payment Trust Building:** Address the 43.1% of non-users who cite distrust in digital payments by prominently showcasing Krishi Connect's escrow-based payment mechanism, adding instant SMS and WhatsApp payment confirmation in Kannada, enabling optional UPI QR code payments at delivery, and publishing monthly transparency reports on successful transaction counts and farmer payouts.
 - 10. Quality Assurance and Certification Support:** To address the buyer concern about produce consistency, implement a voluntary farm-level quality grading system on Krishi Connect where farmers can upload crop photos, soil health card data, and harvest dates. Partner with FSSAI-certified testing laboratories to offer affordable produce testing certificates that can be attached to listings, increasing buyer confidence and enabling premium pricing for certified produce.

CONCLUSION:

This study provides compelling empirical evidence that Krishi Connect, as a direct digital agricultural marketplace, holds significant potential to transform farmer income, reduce supply chain inefficiencies, and democratize market access for smallholder farmers in Karnataka. The Chi-square analyses confirm statistically significant relationships between Krishi Connect adoption and farmer income levels, between buyer awareness and platform satisfaction, and between land-holding size and transaction frequency — all of which validate the platform's core value proposition.

However, the findings also make clear that technology alone is insufficient to solve the structural problems of Indian agricultural marketing. Platform adoption is constrained by real-world barriers — digital illiteracy, poor connectivity, logistics gaps, and payment mistrust — that require concerted interventions from multiple stakeholders including the platform developers, state government, financial institutions, and civil society organizations. The ten strategies proposed in this study provide a practical roadmap for Krishi Connect's next phase of growth.

Ultimately, Krishi Connect represents more than a technology product — it is a structural reform mechanism embedded in a digital interface. If scaled effectively with the right ecosystem support, it has the power to permanently shift bargaining power in favor of India's farmers and create a more equitable agricultural economy. Future research should examine Krishi Connect's impact across other Karnataka districts, explore gender-disaggregated income outcomes, and test the effectiveness of the behavioral interventions proposed herein.

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